Section VII – Terms of Reference

1. Background:-

The Indian Ocean is home to a rich marine flora and fauna (coral reefs, seagrass beds, mangroves, fish, whales, sea turtles,) and recognized as part of the global marine biodiversity hotspot with potential for regeneration. With a combined Exclusive Economic Zones of 5 million square kilometers, the six island territories namely Comoros, Madagascar, Mauritius, Mayotte, Reunion and Seychelles represent a strong tourism potential owing to the marine assets, rich cultural heritage, and unique island economies making the Indian Ocean a premier tourism destination. Nearly 80% of foreigners and visitors are drawn to the coasts, making the ocean the essence of local economies, creating jobs, and bringing in vital foreign currency.

However, the adverse effects of climate change, such as global warming, cyclones, floods, and other natural disasters, have rendered the marine environments of these islands increasingly fragile, with some areas already under threat. Additionally, human pressures on the coastlines, including unplanned hotel and bungalow construction, oil spills, and pollution (land and sea), and irresponsible leisure activities in sensible and fragile areas are accelerating the declination and degradation of the coastal and marine environments. As the ocean ecosystem and marine biodiversity collapse, the entire value chain that depends on healthy ocean (from tourism to fisheries) are also at risk. Additionally, the tourism sector has shown high vulnerability to the impact of covid-19.

In response, the Blue Economy has emerged as a widely recognized pathway to balance economic growth with ocean preservation and conservation. Within this framework, Blue Tourism has emerged as a promising alternative with nature-based, community-driven, and sustainability-focused form of travel that offers island nations a unique opportunity to foster inclusive economic growth across island nations.

As Small Island Developing States (SIDS), the transition from traditional tourism to blue tourism is not just an option, but a necessity. Blue Tourism can serve as a new engine of prosperity, one that safeguards biodiversity, empowers local communities, and aligns with the UN Sustainable Development Goals. By promoting tourism activities that actively regenerate rather than exploit marine ecosystems, SIDS can build a future where economic development and ocean health go hand in hand.

Blue Tourism in the Indian Ocean: Challenges and Opportunities

Tourism is transversal and impact the whole value chain including agriculture, culture and planning amongst others as illustrated in the figure below:



Sustainable tourism refers to tourism activities that are directly connected to marine and coastal ecosystems, including coral reefs, beaches, mangroves, and marine biodiversity. The Sustainable Tourism value chain includes a wide range of components: from ecosystem services and marine-based activities, supporting infrastructure like eco-lodges, marinas, and renewable energy systems. It also encompasses transportation (including cruise tourism), local supply chains (seafood, handicrafts, and agriculture), human

capital development, cultural heritage, marketing and branding of destinations, and the governance frameworks needed to regulate and sustain the sector.

One of the major challenges for Blue Tourism in the Indian Ocean lies in the disparities between the levels of tourism development across the six Indian Ocean islands:

- **Réunion** and **Mayotte** benefit from being French departments, supported by European funding and structured training programs.

- **Mauritius** and **Seychelles** are well-established tourism destinations with consolidated infrastructure and markets.

- **Madagascar** and **Comoros**, on the other hand, face significantly lower levels of development and require greater investment and support to reach their potential.

Tourism development and growth are thus being done at each island's pace whilst neglecting the benefits that the combined resources and assets could bring if explored as a region. This approach is still underdeveloped, especially when compared to competitors like the Caribbean, Mediterranean, or Southeast Asian islands, which have successfully built cooperative regional tourism strategies.

Despite these obstacles, there is significant potential for synergy among Indian Ocean islands and considerable opportunities to develop this sector through regional cooperation, eco-certification schemes, community-based tourism, carbon footprint reduction through sustainable travel initiatives and access to international funding for climate and biodiversity initiatives.

Blue tourism offers a pathway for long-term differentiation and viability. To restore the health of the marine ecosystems and positioning the Indian Ocean as a blue tourism destination, additional efforts are essential in transitioning to more sustainable tourism practices, in line with blue economy development.

2. About Cap Business Océan Indien

Cap Business Océan Indien (CBOI) is the brand image of the Union of the Chambers of Commerce and Industry of the Indian Ocean –UCCIOI, an association registered under the laws of Mauritius, bearing registration no. 13074, regrouping six constitutive territories, namely Comoros, Madagascar, Mauritius, Mayotte, Reunion and Seychelles. Created in 2005, CBOI has become a key actor of regional economic cooperation. The association is now a platform that represents the private sectors of the six islands of the Indian ocean region, for the development and growth of activities related to the oceans, seas and coasts, in the interest of the private sector of its six member states.

CBOI aims to enhance eocnomic cooperation in the region through its various actions and initiatives and has secured funding from the French Development Agency (AFD) to support a five-year regional program (2021-2026) through its feuille de route 2021-2026, focusing on five priority areas with a public private sector collaborative approach :

1. Ocean/ Blue Economy,
2. Energy/ Construction,
3. Sustainable tourism,
4. Agriculture/ Agro-industry and
5. Connectivity

In addition to these priority sectors, CBOI has identified the following cross-cutting issues to guide its actions: climate, biodiversity, inclusion, and circular economy.

3. Objectives of the Services:

The current Request for Proposals (RFP) relates to the provision of Technical Assistance for '**Developing the Blue Tourism Cluster for the Indian Ocean'**, that promotes blue tourism, biodiversity regeneration, economic development, and regional collaboration in line with the Action Plan for Sustainable Tourism in the six island territories (Comores, Madagascar, Maurice, Réunion, Mayotte et Seychelles) of the Indian Ocean.

I. Scope of Services, Tasks (Components) and Expected Deliverables

This technical assistance is structured around **four components and six specific objectives (SO)** with expected deliverables through:

- **A Blue Tourism Blueprint** with a concrete and actionable timeline over the next three years
- The establishment of an **online technical platform** to facilitate knowledge sharing and collaboration with the private stakeholders.
- **Capacity building programmes** to strengthen skills, practices, and institutional frameworks.

The private stakeholders refer to the players in the hospitality, tourism, leisure, and restaurant industries, the broader blue economy sectors, as well as the financing and the fisheries sector.

SO1: Literature Review Report

Literature review is an essential first step to ensure that the technical assistance builds upon existing knowledge, avoids duplication, identify major gaps and aligns with ongoing national, regional and international initiatives to ensure coherence with donor priorities (e.g. AFD, EU, WB and UN SDGs), and private sector initiatives. The themes to be covered include but not limited to the impact of tourism on the environment, blue economy and blue tourism strategies, marine and coastal ecosystem management, climate resilience, and examples of regional cooperation.

The first chapter of the report will include the following:

(i) A comprehensive review and analysis of existing literature, academic studies, data, technical reports, policy documents, and international best practices related to blue tourism in the Indian Ocean region.
(ii) Data gaps, research, and policies that need to be addressed through the project.

SO2: Blue Tourism Cluster Development Plan

This objective aims to develop a blueprint for Blue Tourism based on the CBOI's Action Plan for Sustainable Tourism and will include a three-year Action Plan with a clear roadmap on how the cluster will be developed, implemented, and maintained. The aim is to identify enabling factors, challenges, barriers, and opportunities to create a regional sustainability framework that supports marine biodiversity regeneration, climate-resilient business models, and a transition towards a Blue Tourism Cluster with positive environmental and economic impact.

The activity will include a comparative policy and regulatory frameworks of the six island territories to evaluate their readiness and capacity to support the development of a Blue Tourism Cluster in line with key international commitments on climate change and biodiversity preservation in line with the Sustainable Development Goals, including the Paris Agreement (COP21), the Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD) and the Nagoya Protocol and other relevant global frameworks promoting sustainable and inclusive development.

The Blueprint will include the following:

(i) Recommendations for the implementation of a regional sustainability framework for blue tourism in the Indian Ocean.
(ii) Mapping of the blue tourism value chains and identification of key activities that can be developed.
(iii) Blue tourism cluster stakeholders' engagement matrix.
(iv) Identification of proposed geographic zones in each territory where key tourism products and services are already present or have potential, along with recommendations for low-carbon infrastructure and nature-based solutions that support the regeneration of marine biodiversity and sustainable tourist flows along the value chains.
(v) Benchmarking exercise on best practices for a regional Blue Tourism Cluster of the Indian Ocean including the comparative analysis and case studies of successful models (governance, financing, eco-certification, biodiversity regeneration, community engagement).
(vi) A detailed three-year Action Plan, including strategic objectives, timelines, responsible parties, measurable indicators, funding opportunities, and mechanisms for coordination and monitoring of implementation at both national and regional levels.

SO3: Stakeholder Engagement

This objective draws on the Action 1 – Indian Ocean Sustainable Tourism Technical Committee of the Action Plan for sustainable tourism. The aim is to establish a collaborative platform and mobilize stakeholder participation in technical committees, validation workshops, and regional consultations to provide them with the opportunity to share their expertise and perspectives for achieving the outcomes of the blue tourism cluster. The goal is to strengthen ownership and alignment from coastal and island communities directly impacted by tourism and marine activities.

This objective will include the following:

- Establishing a technical committee regrouping the stakeholders to define the key actions and structure of the regional platform.
- Development of an online platform for the technical committee.
- Assisting CBOI in addressing technical issues raised during preliminary discussions and consultations.
- Regional workshop for engaging the stakeholders through workshops with a minimum of 50 stakeholders from the private sector of the region and enabling them to share, co-create, promote and give visibility to the Indian Ocean Blue Tourism Initiatives.

SO4: Capacity building

This objective is to achieve the capacity building program in line with OS2 and the Action Plan for Sustainable Tourism, targeted at all six island territories. The aim is to provide technical support and accompany existing entreprises, especially SMEs and community-based operators in the tourism and blue economy sector with the necessary skills and knowledge to develop, implement, and market new tourism products and services which have the potential to transform their activities as per the requirements for sustainability integration of the blueprint.

The key activities will include the following:

- Survey exercise to assess existing capacity, knowledge and skill gaps, and resource requirements.
- Technical support strategy for small entreprises of the tourism and blue economy sectors focusing on capacity-building, access to finance, marketing support, and compliance with sustainability standards.

- Development of a capacity-building program to accompany the entreprises with technical expertise and skills in areas such as blue economy and blue tourism product development, low carbon impact measures that can be integrated along their activities, climate adaptation and risk mitigation, and compliance with eco-certification schemes (e.g., GSTC-aligned standards).
- Capacity building workshops, and webinars with at least 50 entreprises, relevant stakeholders and agencies involved in vocational and academic trainings
- Designing an evaluation tool to monitor and record the enterprise progress and provide technical assistance to ensure effective implementation of sustainable tourism practices.

SO5: Financing strategy

This objective will ensure the successful implementation of the Blue Tourism Cluster in the six island territories. The aim is to identify sustainable and innovative financing mechanisms that will support the implementation of the initiatives and actions outlined in the blueprint for spearheading growth and development of the Blue Tourism cluster whilst ensuring biodiversity regeneration. The goal is to develop and establish a dedicated funding mechanism that mobilizes funding from both public and private sector investment, regional and international funding instruments to be allocated to all the actors that will contribute to the success of the Blue Tourism Cluster across the six island territories.

This objective will include the following activities:

- Identification of existing and potential funding sources at local, regional and international levels, related to sustainable tourism, blue economy, climate adaptation, coastal management, marine resources management, biodiversity conservation and sustainable developments amongst others
- Analysis of markets and funding mechanisms aligned with blue economy and sustainable tourism development goals, such as green and blue bonds, climate adaptation and resilience funds, green and blue carbon credits, marine biodiversity offset markets, and impact investment funds for ecotourism in line with blue economy development.
- Assisting CBOI to design and prepare funding proposals and investment pitch that address the needs and challenges of the various segments of the blue tourism cluster to present to donor agencies, investors and financing institutions.

SO6: Indian Ocean Blue Tourism Brand

This objective of SO6 is to establish a regional identity for Blue Tourism in the Indian Ocean through the development of a unified regional brand. The aim is to allow a coherent and cohesive approach in using the brand as strategic tools for marketing, positioning and promoting the Indian Ocean as a sustainable and high-value tourism destination on the global market. The brand will support the differentiation of the six island territories as a leading destination for sustainable travel, enhance their international visibility, and reinforce market access for sustainable tourism and blue economy operators aligned with sustainability standards. The brand will be used to seek an official eco-certification for tourism enterprises, products, and services (as per the recommendations of the blueprint) to meet specific sustainability criteria aligned with the Global Sustainable Tourism Council (GSTC) standards and adapted to the specific environmental and socio-economic context of the six island territories. The goal is to finalise and launch the Indian Ocean Blue Tourism Brand that encapsulates the shared values of the six island territories, historical and cultural wealth, biodiversity, climate conscious innovation, environmental sustainability, and regional cooperation.

This objective will include the following activities:

- Validation of the proposed brand concept, logo design and attributes with the relevant stakeholders through the regional stakeholders' platform.
- Technical support to CBOI for the design of a regional communication and promotion strategy for

the Blue Tourism Cluster, emphasizing its added value, sustainability credentials, and contribution to regional development and ocean conservation.

- Assist CBOI in the positioning of the brand based with the supporting narratives on all six islands under a common vision of regenerative marine tourism, community empowerment, and ocean resilience.
- Assist CBOI's communication team to promote the brand globally by creating contents that will enhance the digital presence of the brand (website, social media, and marketing materials) and attract target markets (tourists, impact investors, and sustainability-oriented entreprises).
- Develop the eco-certification framework with clear certification criteria, operational procedures, and implementation guidelines.
- Create awareness of the eco-certification through the regional stakeholders' platform and assist CBOI to obtain formal recognition with authorities, regional and international partners.
- Identify and explore synergies for using the brand with local schemes such as tax relief, investment incentives, financing criteria and marketing advantages for certified entreprises.

4. Team Composition & Qualification Requirements for the Key Experts (and any other requirements which will be used for evaluating the Key Experts under Sub-Clause 21.1 of the Data Sheet)

The team of experts must demonstrate their ability to provide technical assistance across all components of the assignment, including research, planning, stakeholder engagement, policy analysis, capacity building, financing, and branding. The expertise mobilized should reflect both international best practices and regional/local knowledge relevant to the islands of Comoros, Madagascar, Mauritius, Mayotte, Réunion, and Seychelles. The expert team should comprise no more than six (6) experts with complementary profiles.

In addition to their specific areas, all experts are expected to work collaboratively and engage in the following activities:

- Designing and planning sustainable tourism clusters, including zoning, low-carbon infrastructure, and marine biodiversity regeneration.
- Organise and conduct stakeholders working groups with the public and private sector
- Contribute to the co-creation of the three-year Action Plan.
- Work collaboratively to ensure integration across all technical outputs and alignment with the project's sustainability objectives.

Expert Mobilisation Table:

Expert (add rows as needed based on the number of experts mobilised)	**Area of Expertise**	**Objectives**	**Number of Days of On-Site Mobilisation (per country)**	**Total Number of Mobilisation Days**
Expert 1				
Expert 2				
Expert 3				
Expert ...				
Expert N				

The requirements for the key experts are as follows:

Expert 1: Team Leader / Sustainable development, Climate Change Specialist

Qualifications: Advanced university degree (Master's or equivalent) in Sustainable development, Coastal Management, Environmental Sciences, Climate Change, or related fields.

Experience: Minimum 7 years of relevant professional experience, including leadership roles managing multi-disciplinary and regional projects focused on sustainable coastal and marine tourism development, Blue Tourism, and climate change adaptation. Demonstrated expertise in Blue Tourism development, climate change adaptation, marine biodiversity conservation, and low-carbon infrastructure planning in island or Small Island Developing States (SIDS) contexts will be an advantage.

Language: English (written and spoken), spoken French is an advantage.

Role and Responsibilities:

- Provide overall leadership and coordination of the expert team and project activities to ensure integrated and high-quality delivery of technical assistance.
- Lead the technical development of the Blue Tourism Cluster blueprint including identification of geographic zones, key tourism products, low-carbon infrastructure, marine biodiversity regeneration, and climate change adaptation strategies tailored for the Indian Ocean islands.
- Ensure integration of Blue Economy principles into cluster development and alignment with regional sustainable tourism objectives.
- Support the preparation of reports and the three-year action plan aligned with Blue Economy principles including relevant funding opportunities, regional sustainable tourism goals, and climate resilience objectives.

Expert 2: Stakeholder Engagement and Facilitation Specialist

Qualifications: Bachelor's degree in Social Sciences, Political Science, Development Studies, Business Administration or related field. A master's degree would be an advantage.

Experience: Minimum 5 years of professional experience in stakeholder mapping, engagement, and facilitation, preferably in the Blue Economy, tourism, environmental sectors or relevant field of SIDS. Demonstrated ability to work with diverse groups, including government agencies, private sector, NGOs, research institutions, and local communities, especially in island or regional contexts will be an advantage.

Language: English (written and spoken), spoken French is an advantage.

Role and Responsibilities:

- Lead the mapping and analysis of key stakeholders involved in Blue Tourism and the Blue Economy across the Indian Ocean islands.
- Design and facilitate participatory workshops, consultations, and technical committee meetings at national and regional levels.
- Foster collaboration and co-creation among public, private, and community stakeholders to build ownership of the Blue Tourism Cluster.
- Support documentation and reporting of stakeholder engagement processes and outcomes.
- Conduct capacity building exercices with SMEs or tourism to support the adoption of sustainable practices and green innovation.
- Develop tools and frameworks to monitor and evaluate capacity building outcomes.

Expert 3: Branding and Communication Specialist

Qualifications: Bachelor's degree in marketing, Communication, Cultural Studies, or related field. Alternatively, a minimum of 3 years' experience working in a management position in these areas.

Language: English (written and spoken), spoken French is an advantage.

Experience: Experience in destination branding, sustainable tourism marketing, with an emphasis on sustainability and community values.

Role and Responsibilities:

- Lead the development of the Indian Ocean Blue Tourism brand identity, integrating sustainability, culture, innovation, and regional connectivity.
- Develop messaging, promotional materials, and stakeholder engagement tools to support brand adoption and visibility.
- Coordinate with regional stakeholders to ensure brand alignment and consistent communication.

Expert N: Secondary experts

The services of secondary experts with technical knowledge and knowhow can be requested to assist in the sustainable product development, low-carbon operations, and market positioning aligned with the Blue Tourism Cluster blueprint with the aim to foster strong collaboration with the relevant stakeholders and ensure the practical applicability and impact of sustainability initiatives.

5. Reporting Requirements and Time Schedule for Deliverables:

All deliverables shall be submitted to the Project Manager of Cap Business Indian Ocean. Any requests for corrections, revisions, or clarifications will be addressed by the service provider at no additional cost until the deliverable is formally approved by the Project Manager.

5.1. The service provider should submit the following:

- Literature review report
- Inception report
- Blueprint with three year Action Plan

5.2. The following capacity building (CB) exercise must be conducted during the project:

- Stakeholders' engagement workshop with at least 50 stakeholders.
- One regional capacity building event: The Move Event
- Capacity building workshops in all the six territories (hybrid/online).
- Blueprint and Validation workshop with technical committee.

Deliverables

Specific Objectives	Key Activities	Deliverables	Format	Timeframe
Component 1A SO1: Literature Review Report	a. Review of industrial and technical reports, policy document, best practices b. Identification of the data gaps, research, and policies that need to be addressed through the project.	a. Draft Literature Review; Final Literature Review Report (with gaps & recommendations)	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M1
Component 1B SO2: Blue Tourism Cluster	a. Comparative analysis of policy/regulatory frameworks across the six territories.	a. Recommendations for the implementation of a regional sustainability framework in line with international	PDF, Word	M1 - M3

Development Plan		conventions on climate change and biodiversity conservation.		
	b. Mapping of the value chains related to blue tourism and identification of key activities	b. Blue Tourism Value Chain with key activities.	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M1 - M3
	c. Provide a list of public and private stakeholders, industry associations, entreprises, local communities, NGOs pertaining to c.	c. A comprehensive and representative stakeholders' engagement matrix linked to SO3.	PDF, Word, Excel PowerPoint	M1 - M3
	d. Provide a list of the proposed geographic zones for blue tourism products and services.	d. Geospatial zoning report and map for blue tourism activities.	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M1 - M3
	e. Benchmarking exercise.	e. Benchmarking Report	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M1 - M3
	f. Inception report: Drafting of three year Action and Blueprint for the Blue Tourism Cluster Development Plan	f. Inception report including the literature review report, draft Action Plan.	PDF, Word	M1 - M3
Component 2A SO3: Stakeholder Engagement	a. Establish a technical committee per island of the key stakeholders.	a. Technical committee established.	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M2 - M5
	b. Develop an online platform for the technical committee.	b. Online platform established.	NA	M2 - M5
	c. Validation of the Inception report in connection with SO2.	c. Stakeholders' engagement workshop with at least 50 stakeholders.	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M2 - M5
Component 2B SO4: Capacity Building	a. Conduct a regional capacity needs assessment linked to the stakeholders' engagement matrix.	a. Skills gap survey report.	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M4 - M6
	b. Design a training strategy with clear ToR for the technical assistance to be provided.	b. Technical support strategy.	PDF, Word	M4 - M6
	c. Co-organisation with Cap Business IO of the 'The Move-Blue Tourism' event, the regional workshop, with a minimum of 50 stakeholders from the private sector of the region and enabling them to share, co-create, promote and give visibility to the Indian Ocean Blue Tourism Initiatives.	c. 1 regional capacity building event: The Move.	NA	M4 - M6
	d. Conduct capacity building programmes.	d. Capacity building workshops conducted in all	NA	M4 - M6

		the six territories (hybrid/online).		
	e. Create a monitoring and evaluation tool.	e. Monitoring and evaluation toolkit.	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M4 - M6
Component 3 SO5: Financing strategy	a. Identify potential funding sources at local, regional and international level	a. Funding sources report.	PDF, Word	M6 - M7
	b. Analyse financing mechanisms.	b. Financing strategy document.	PDF, Word	M6 - M7
	c. Prepare template for funding proposals and investment pitch for Cap Business OI to accompany the entreprises in their transition from traditional to blue tourism.	c. Validation of report, draft proposals and pitch deck with technical committee.	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M6 - M7
Component 4 SO6: Indian Ocean Blue Tourism Brand	a. Brand concept, logo design and attributes.	a. Brand concept note, logo and identity.	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M6 - M8
	b. Communication material for Cap Business OI's communication team.	b. Communication and promotion strategy; digital content package.	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M6 - M8
	c. Eco-certification framework and guidelines including list of local schemes such as tax relief, investment incentives, financing criteria and marketing advantages for certified entreprises.	c. Eco-certification framework (brand package, manual, guidelines and toolkit).	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M6 - M8
	d. Submission of final Blueprint, brand concept note, logo and identity and eco-certification framework.	d. Validation workshop with technical committee.	PDF, Word, PowerPoint	M7 - M8
	e. Presentation of the Blueprint and formal recognition with authorities, regional and international partners.	e. Launching of logo event and presentation of Blueprint and eco-certification framework .	NA	M8

Contact details for submission of reports and deliverables:

Name	Title	Email
Virginie Lauret	Directrice	direction@capbusiness.io
Nawshin Mahadooa	Chargée de Mission	ocean@capbusiness.io

Calendar

The technical assistance should be realized within 8 months following notification of the contract. The service provider shall include a clear schedule outlining their proposed organization of the assignment by components. The schedule shall specify the delivery dates of the deliverables.

6. Professional and support counterpart personnel to be assigned by the Client to the Consultant's team: Nawshin Mahadooa, Chargée de Mission Blue Economy, Sustainable Tourism, Maritime Connectivity.